About the author



Alphonse Daudet (1840-1897) was a French novelist and short-story writer. The Last Lesson is set in the days of the Franco-Prussian War (1870-1871) in which France was defeated by Prussia led by Bismarck. Prussia then consisted of what now are the nations of Germany, Poland and parts of Austria. In this story the French districts of Alsace and Lorraine have passed into Prussian hands.

Glossary

chirping (v) - making a short, sharp high pitched sound (usually by small. birds or insects)

bustle (v) - move in an energetic manner

unison (n) - simultaneous utterance of words

rapping (v) - striking with a series of rapid audible blows

thumbed (v) - a book which has been read often and bearing the marks of frequent handling

cranky (adj.) - strange

Saar - a river in northeastern France and western Germany

Angelus (n) - a Roman Catholic devotion commemorating the Incarnation of Jesus and including the Hail Mary, said at morning, noon, and sunset.

"Vive la France!" - is an expression used in French to show patriotism. It›s difficult to translate the term literally into English, but it generally means "Long live France!"

A. Answer the following questions in two or three sentences:

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1. Why did Franz dread to go to school that day?
2. What were the various things that tempted Franz to spend his day outdoors?
3. Why was the narrator not able to get to his desk without being seen?
4. What was Frank sorry for?
5. Why were the old villagers sitting in the last desk?
6. What were the thoughts of the narrator's parents?
7. Why does M. Hamel say that we must guard our language?
8. M. Hamel was gazing at many things. What were they?
9. When and how did M. Hamel bid farewell to the class?

B. Answer the following questions in about 100-150 words:

1. We appreciate the value of something only when we are about to lose it. Explain this with reference to the French language and M.Hamel.
2. Give an account of the last day of M.Hamel in school.

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